THE NIFTY DASHBOARD

EMPOWERING COMPANY GROWTH THROUGH TECHNOLOGY

nifty marketing

WHY A DASHBOARD?

Nifty is in a fragmented state. There are very few standards. The ones we do have are imperfectly implemented. Each team has their own way of doing things — their own unique resources and processes. Beyond that, information is siloed in dozens of places.

The cause of this is that, until now, Nifty has operated as a startup. Part of being a startup is being nimble – meaning each employee's responsibilities are never fully defined. But as we grow, introducing more structure will be critical to continued success.

Everything to this point has mostly been due to a mix of individual skill and luck. Problems we have had in the past have remained hidden until there was a breaking point.

It's time to proactively find problems, or better yet, prevent them from happening in the first place. It's time to introduce more order and structure. It's time to bring clarity to the now-vague roles and responsibilities of employees.

Having a central web-based dashboard can help us accomplish these goals. The dashboard will serve as central source of information about our clients, processes, and company performance. In many ways, the dashboard will function as a CRM. It will hold all of our data and allows us to get insights on that data.

Eventually, we'll be able to introduce standardized expectations and roles monitored by the dashboard. This means the dashboard will guide Project Managers (PMs) through preset processes and help simplify the role of being a PM.

The end goal of this dashboard is to empower growth and bring noticeable benefits to Project Managers (PMs), clients, and upper management.

WHERE WE ARE NOW

BOTTLENECKS AND FRUSTRATIONS

1,954

Hours Dedicated To Reporting in 2017

This number includes reviewing of reports, compiling them, and sending them off.

The average report takes **3 hours**. 80% of compiling a report is gathering data. The dashboard should be able to reduce total reporting time **by 75% to 45 minutes.**

The client can still be charged three hours, because we are providing the same value — we just got more efficient.

Total Estimated Savings: $146,250

204.5

Hours Logging KPIs in 2017

Assuming an employee's time is worth **$100/hr**, nearly $20,500 has been spent on internal reporting.

This is reporting that could be entirely automated.

Total Estimated Savings: $20,500

**All data is sourced from Nifty Harvest Reports for all employees for the year of 2017.*

10+

Different Tools

Asana. Email. Random Notepads. Google Sheets. People's Brains. ALabs. GMB.

People have to log into several tools or client accounts to get the information they need, or just to get a handle on how a client is doing.

Assuming a conservative **5 minutes** each day logging into accounts and finding metrics or status updates, this would equal about **20 hours of lost time per employee.** The dashboard can eliminate this.

Total Estimated Savings:
$40,000

5 MINUTES X 48 WEEKS X 5 DAYS X 20 EMPLOYEES = **400 HOURS OF SAVED TIME**

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Missed Errors
& Opportunities

How many times has a PM missed something only to be castigated by the client later?

Dozens.

We have anecdotal stories to back this up.

TOTAL ESTIMATED SAVINGS:

$206,750+/YEAR

Information Fragmentation

Right now we have information distributed across dozens of places. Email. Google Sheets. Dropbox. Random Notepads on strategist computers. Asana. This doesn't even mention all of our analytics tools: G Analytics, Ahrefs, Bright Local, Callrail, and GMB.

Associates put status updates in Asana tasks, comments in Google Sheets, and Google Hangout chats. With so many potential points of storage, things are bound to get lost. The dashboard will serve as a central note taking place that anyone can see.

How quickly can anyone answer questions like:

- How long has x client been with us?
- How has the number of client reviews changed over time?
- Who is the PM for x project?
- Is there a conflict of interest issue for this prospect?
- Where does an employee go to request vacation?
- Where are the kickoff questionnaires?
- How many total clients do we currently have?
- What's our recurring revenue?
- Why did client x quit?

Maybe we can answer most of these, but it will take a lot of time. A dashboard would provide this information much faster.

We foresee the dashboard being a "one-stop" place to find answers. Whether its trainings or specific client information. The goal is to avoid having our people dig through Google Sheets, email, or Dropbox to get answers they need. They don't need to dig through old reports to find some obscure reference.

The dashboard will also act as a central source of training material. Having a central learning location is key. The big benefit of the dashboard is that we can have a dynamic set of information. Having a static manual is akin to giving someone a book and telling them to find the answer. We'd rather have a searchable resource that gives them Nifty-approved answers from multiple viewpoints and that can be updated in a matter of seconds.

Mental Overload + Inconsistent Implementation

If there's anything PMs do on a daily basis, it's react & adapt. What emails came in today? What phone calls? What Google updates? What gains or losses are there? What roadblocks are my team running into? What internal requests has management given?

The constant influx of new challenges through phone, email, hangouts, and in-person conversations are what make the Project Management role so hectic, stressful, and hard to define.

Another aspect of Project Management that makes it hard to define is that each Project Manager has their own unique approach. Certain PMs don't follow certain guidelines - for better or worse. They are rogue agents, which is great for a startup. But this hampers predictability and accountability.

For example, some PMs use the outsourcing sheet. Other's don't. Some use their own proprietary linkbuilding sheets, while others use official company ones.

We rely on people right now, not systems. This is fine to a point, but people aren't perfect. Our goal with the dashboard is to introduce structure without killing freedom. We want to create systems respectful of human psychology that help Nifty get better.

How does this look? One example is automated reminders, which force people to act. This allows them to rely on the dashboard, rather then a list of to-dos, which reduces mental load.

> ***I can't check every one of my client's stats on a daily basis. There just isn't enough time.***
>
> *— Anonymous Senior Marketing Strategist*

The dashboard can help PMs in multiple ways, including:

- ✔ Alleviating internal responsibilities, such as KPI reports, to shift more time into what's important.
- ✔ Enabling Proactivity. The dashboard can catch problems before clients do, allowing PMs to deal with the issue in a calm matter.
- ✔ Giving a structure and framework that a PM can react within. For example, showing exactly how much can be outsourced.
- ✔ Giving standardized reactions, solutions and tools. Particular situations have a way of showing up over and over again. By having standardized processes and responses in place, PMs don't have to stress about finding the solution.
- ✔ Clear delineation of what Nifty does and doesn't do.
- ✔ Clear delineation of which departments handle what. This is a part of role definition. We want to restrict PMs to handle certain, distinct areas of responsibility, while retaining freedom within those areas. Doing this, prevents gaps and overlaps.
- ✔ Providing a central communication point across the entire team.

> ***I just want to focus on my clients and what they need. I don't care much for these internal reports.***
>
> *— Anonymous Senior Marketing Strategist*

> ***I don't really know how much I can outsource, so I just outsource however much feels right.***
>
> *— Anonymous Senior Marketing Strategist*

BENEFITS OF THE DASHBOARD

There are strong benefits for the client, PMs, and Nifty.

Client Benefits

- We find problems much sooner — before the client does — allowing us to be proactive and pre-empt client complaints.
- PMs and their teams spend less time on internal reports and more times delighting their clients.
- Higher Quality Work.

Project Managers

- Less Time Spent on Reporting.
- Easier Access to Information.
- Given an adaptable structure and further clarity on what they need to do.
- Better Job Satisfaction. Happier PMs = less burnout, longer retention, and clarity. Less likely to be caught off guard or stuck putting out fires.

Company

- Smoother transitions from across PMs/teams.
- Automated checks to make sure PMs don't fall behind and that work is getting done.
- Gained efficiencies mean PM's are able to take on more clients, which also reduces the number of new hires we need to take on.

DASHBOARD USE-CASE EXAMPLES

- A home screen that displays the current Outsourcing Ratio + Remaining Outsourceable Hours.
- The ability to check on client details that matter within seconds. How much budget do I have, what am I waiting on, what are the metrics?
- Auto-generated *internal* reports that give insights to management and PMs – without taking PM time.
- Auto-generated data for monthly client reports.
- Reminders if significant budget is remaining and the report date is close by.
- Automated checks that can reveal if a client site goes down (Groth), if domain redirects stop working (Schultz Myers), if there is a significant drop in rankings, or if a large number of pages are de-indexed (due to accidental no-index of pages in Colwell's case).
- Find macro-trends based on aggregated data from all our clients. For example, what if we were able to have average metrics based on industry. Perhaps we would see that all Divorce lawyers see a big drop in December and a huge spike in January. With this kind of data we could know at a glance if a client has a big problem, or is just facing seasonal trends. This is just one example of how we can leverage all the data we have. There may be other unpredictable benefits that will only show themselves once we have the data.
- Central note-taking. If associate runs into a roadblock, it's documented. There are no more random notepads.

DEVELOPMENT ROADMAP

When it comes to tool development, there are really two major approaches: **Waterfall** and **Agile Development**.

The **Waterfall** approach divides a project into multiple stages and requires each stage to be completed before moving to the next. This approach is suited to big, monolithic apps which are completely pre-planned.

The **Agile** approach is based on constant iteration. There are consistent 'sprints' in which new features are added.

The Nifty dashboard will use the Agile method. This is because this method is more flexible and adaptable. The waterfall method requires huge time investments up front. And if any changes are introduced, it can stop development for high periods of time. With Agile, we can pivot based on if something is or isn't working. There is a much higher risk of failure with the Waterfall method.

An example of a web platform that relies on agile development is Asana. Three years ago Asana didn't have "Due Times" or "Start Dates". That didn't make Asana useless three years ago, rather, it's gotten better and more feature-packed: https://asana.com/guide/help/faq/release-notes

In the same way, we are starting off small with the dashboard. The first step will be creating a foundational database that can store information unique to each client. After that, we'll start adding features like automatic site checks and automated reporting.

There will be no 'final' product or web app when it comes to the dashboard. Rather, there will be constant updates that introduce new features on a regular basis. Every sprint, we'll work on adding new features. Some are further out than others — like Asana/Harvest integration.

DEVELOPMENT TIMELINE

Due to the agile method, we cannot give exact timelines on when a specific feature will be added. Instead, we can give you an overall framework we expect to follow.

We will start by getting the basic integrations implemented and beta testing with 1-2 PMs. We want to make sure we're empowering PMs and making the dashboard intuitive, rather than a burden.

Once we have PMs happy, we'll implement the admin tools that give the managing director a big picture overview of company performance.

Ideally, by month six, we should have our first iteration of the dashboard ready.

Beyond month six, there are no specific promises. The Agile method is based on flexibility. This means we can reprioritize features based on company needs.

If an API breaks, we can delay a new feature and instead restore the broken functionality.

All that to say:
Some results and ROI will be evident immediately, others will take time. It's very similar to what we tell clients about SEO. There are quick wins we can implement (and those can be powerful). But the biggest changes can take 12-18 months.

If you're interested in learning more about Waterfall vs Agile, check out:
http://www.commonplaces.com/blog/agile-v-waterfall-how-to-approach-your-web-development-project/

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

Of course the biggest questions shareholders have are:

- **How will the dashboard make money?**
  - The dashboard makes money by allowing PMs to take on more clients (eliminating the cost of hiring more people) by introducing efficiencies. It also increases retention by proactively revealing problems and empowering higher quality work.

- **When will it make money?**
  - The first iteration of the dashboard can be ready in as little as six months. The first iteration will introduce major new efficiencies. Further efficiencies will be attained with future iterations.

- **What is the total cost?**
  - This is a recurring project that will require perpetual maintenance.

- **How feasible is everything promised?**
  - Automated reporting and alerts are very feasible. When we get into Asana and Harvest integrations, it gets murkier. However, we are confident we'll find solutions when the time comes.

- **How long before we have something tangible?**
  - As mentioned earlier, the first iteration should be done within 3 months.

- **What are the risks?**
  - The biggest risks are going to be adoption and broken APIs. Broken APIs can't be mitigated. Ensuring widespread adoption will require working closely with PMs and getting buy in.

WORKING TOWARD A SOLUTION

The biggest mistake we can make is say we need to have everything figured out before taking action. We'll never know everything. If we want to make progress, we have to take baby steps. Getting caught up in the minutia now is detrimental. It's only by moving forward that we can start finding solutions.

There are compelling reasons for the dashboard. Giving more structure and centralizing our data will bring major benefits to clients, project managers and management. This will help put Nifty on a sustainable path to growth.